

# Fertitta Goes All In: \$17.6B Caesars Buyout Reshapes Gaming Real Estate in May 2026

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**\$17.6 b**

Market Data

**\$11.9 b**

Market Data

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**\$31**

Market Data

On a Thursday morning in late May, Tilman Fertitta did what no other casino operator has done in a generation: he bought Caesars Entertainment outright. The all-cash transaction, valued at \$17.6 billion, includes the assumption of approximately \$11.9 billion of Caesars' outstanding debt. Shareholders will receive \$31 per share in cash, a 49 percent premium to the unaffected share price as of Feb. 25.

NEW YORK - 2026-05-28

Light Tower Group Analysis

Fertitta Entertainment already owns the Golden Nugget chain, the Landry's restaurant empire, and the Houston Rockets. Now it adds Caesars' more than 50 resorts across the United States. The combined entity will be private, controlled entirely by Fertitta. The deal closes a process that began in March, when Fertitta made an initial \$7 billion bid. That offer was lower in equity value than the final \$5.7 billion equity component, but the structure shifted. Fertitta beat a competing bid from Carl Icahn's firm, per Commercial Observer reporting.

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Debt & Equity

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*That continuity signals Fertitta values the existing operating team, at least for now.*

Caesars CEO Tom Reeg, CFO Bret Yunker, and President Anthony Carano will remain in their roles. That continuity signals Fertitta values the existing operating team, at least for now. No closing date was announced.

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Light Tower Group Analysis

The all-cash structure matters. Fertitta is not relying on debt markets to finance this acquisition. He is deploying his own balance sheet, which means no syndication risk, no lender covenants, no public market pressure. That is a luxury few buyers have in 2026. PJT Partners served as exclusive financial adviser. The firm's role suggests a streamlined process, not a broad auction. Fertitta's relationship with PJT likely predates this deal, given his history of large-scale hospitality transactions.

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Policy

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Shares of Caesars rose over 2.5 percent in pre-market trading and opened above 1 percent. The market reaction was muted, reflecting the fact that the deal was widely expected after Fertitta's March bid and Icahn's exit.

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The \$31 per share price represents a 49 percent premium to the unaffected price. That is a substantial premium, but it also reflects Caesars' depressed valuation amid rising interest rates and concerns about consumer spending on gaming and travel. Fertitta's track record with the Golden Nugget chain demonstrates his ability to integrate and operate casino properties. He bought the Golden Nugget Lake Charles in 2019 and has since expanded the brand. The Caesars portfolio is larger and more complex, with properties ranging from the Las Vegas Strip to regional casinos.

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Key Metric

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The assumption of \$11.9 billion in debt is the critical financial detail. Caesars carried significant leverage from its 2020 acquisition by Eldorado Resorts. Fertitta is not restructuring that debt; he is inheriting it. The combined entity's debt load will be substantial, but Fertitta's private ownership means he can manage it without quarterly earnings pressure.

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Light Tower Group Analysis

This deal signals a shift in gaming real estate ownership. Public market valuation has constrained Caesars' ability to invest in properties and compete with private operators. Fertitta's private structure allows him to make long-term capital decisions without shareholder scrutiny. The broader implication for commercial real estate is clear: private capital is consolidating the gaming and hospitality sector. Fertitta's all-cash bid demonstrates that family office and billionaire balance sheets can outmaneuver public companies and private equity firms in large-scale acquisitions. The cost of debt may be high, but the cost of equity is higher for public companies facing valuation discounts.

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*The Golden Nugget portfolio has performed well, but Caesars' regional properties face competition from new supply and changing consumer preferences.*

For lenders and investors, the question is whether Fertitta can generate sufficient cash flow from Caesars' properties to service the \$11.9 billion in assumed debt. The Golden Nugget portfolio has performed well, but Caesars' regional properties face competition from new supply and changing consumer preferences. Fertitta's operational expertise will be tested at scale.

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Light Tower Group Analysis

The deal also raises questions about the future of gaming real estate investment trusts. Caesars' properties are largely owned by VICI Properties, a triple-net lease REIT. Fertitta's acquisition does not change that structure, but his long-term plans for property ownership are unclear. He may seek to acquire properties from VICI over time, or he may maintain the lease structure. Fertitta's bet is that private ownership and operational control will unlock value that public markets could not. The \$17.6 billion price tag is a wager on his ability to run Caesars better than its previous owners. If he succeeds, the deal will be remembered as the moment gaming real estate shifted from public to private hands. If he fails, the debt will be the anchor.

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# LIGHT TOWER GROUP

INSTITUTIONAL CAPITAL ADVISORY

## ABOUT

Benjamin Rohr is the Principal of Light Tower Group, a New York-based institutional capital advisory firm specializing in debt and equity placement for complex commercial real estate transactions.

## ENGAGE

Principal-led execution. Debt placement, equity structuring, and investment advisory for complex commercial real estate mandates.

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